

SCIENCE OF READING REVIEW: TEACH FOR AMERICA, GREATER DELTA REGION

ALTERNATIVE ROUTE

On-Site Review: March 25-28, 2024

WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

This report uses evidence from an on-site review to examine how an educator preparation program prepares candidates to teach reading using scientific reading instruction, as Arkansas requires of every approved program. It is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

The on-site reviews are carried out by Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US), an external review organization. TPI-US teams inspect coursework and course materials, observe instruction and clinical practice, review program data, and hold focus groups with candidates, faculty, mentor teachers, and school partners. Division of Elementary and Secondary Education staff participate in the review.

TPI-US rates the program in the three review areas of the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

- Review Area 1, "Quality of Literacy Coursework," is rated from course materials, syllabi, assignments, and observations of instruction.
- Review Area 2, "Quality of Field-Based Experiences," is rated from placement records, observation and feedback evidence, and focus groups with candidates, mentor teachers, faculty, and school partners.
- Review Area 3, "Quality of Performance Management and Continuous Improvement," is rated from program data systems, quality-control checkpoints, monitoring practice, and partnership evidence.

Every review area receives a rating. Depending on the framework version, the report may also rate each criterion; some earlier reports discuss every criterion without stating a separate rating for it. Performance Levels are defined as follows, in language drawn from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

PERFORMANCE LEVEL	WHAT THE RATING MEANS
4 — EXCEEDS	Coursework and training CONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
3 — MEETS	Coursework and training USUALLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
2 — APPROACHING	Coursework and training INCONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
1 — BELOW	Coursework and training RARELY OR DO NOT address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.

TEACH FOR AMERICA, GREATER DELTA REGION

ALTERNATIVE ROUTE

REVIEW AREA PERFORMANCE LEVELS		
REVIEW AREA 1 INSTRUCTION	REVIEW AREA 2 FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES	REVIEW AREA 3 PARTNERSHIPS
BELOW	BELOW	BELOW
CRITERIA REVIEWED		
CORRECTIVE ACTION STATUS		
Corrective action plan in place for this review cycle. This program is carrying out a corrective action plan with the Division covering sixteen actions.		

PROGRAM INFORMATION

INSTITUTION NAME	Teach For America, Greater Delta Region
LOCATION	Greater Delta Region
PROGRAM REVIEWED	Alternative certification program for corps members serving as teachers of record
PATHWAY	Alternative Route
REVIEW FRAMEWORK	TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review Framework (2024)
REVIEWING BODY	Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US)
SITE VISIT DATES	March 25-28, 2024

REVIEW AREA 1: QUALITY OF INSTRUCTION

REVIEW AREA 1 PERFORMANCE LEVEL
BELOW
CRITERION RATINGS
<i>This review states one rating for the review area and discusses the criteria in narrative. It does not state a separate rating for each criterion, so none is published here.</i>
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND
Reviewers examined slide decks, facilitator guides, online materials, and interviews with course designers and facilitators for seven courses, including Science of Reading: What and Why, Science of Reading: Word Recognition, Making Student Thinking Visible, and Using Data to Plan for Writing. They found that coursework supplied resources but lacked models of instructional practice and opportunities to evaluate, select, and use high-quality instructional materials. Concepts of print appeared in no coursework. Facilitators gave inaccurate information on syllabication and on voiced and unvoiced sounds, and did not correct inaccurate answers about organization in writing. Assessments relied on true or false and multiple choice items that did not measure pedagogical content knowledge, and corps members had rare chances to plan, practice, or teach.
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS
• Equip corps members to differentiate instruction for neurodiverse, linguistically diverse, and gifted students • Deepen science of reading coursework with facilitator modeling, peer teaching, fieldwork, and demonstration videos
CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA
Eight of the sixteen corrective actions target this review area.

REVIEW AREA 2: QUALITY OF FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES

REVIEW AREA 2 PERFORMANCE LEVEL
BELOW
CRITERION RATINGS
<i>This review states one rating for the review area and discusses the criteria in narrative. It does not state a separate rating for each criterion, so none is published here.</i>
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND
Reviewers found that because corps members served as teachers of record, the program selected neither clinical placement schools nor mentor teachers. Corps members completed asynchronous summer coursework and a three-week practicum before taking full classroom responsibility. Reviewers found no assurance that corps members encountered high-quality instructional materials during preparation, no monitoring of the credentials of externally supplied coaches, and handbook gaps covering lesson planning, teaching practices, and data sharing. Field experiences with multilingual students and with Tier 1 and Tier 2 practices were rare or inconsistent. Written feedback after observations was not required, and reviewers observed limited informal and no formal assessments.
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS
Implement literacy-specific rubrics and exemplar feedback, and partner with districts to give corps members experience with high-quality instructional materials
CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA
Five of the sixteen corrective actions target this review area.

REVIEW AREA 3: QUALITY OF PARTNERSHIPS

REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE LEVEL
BELOW
CRITERION RATINGS
<i>This review states one rating for the review area and discusses the criteria in narrative. It does not state a separate rating for each criterion, so none is published here.</i>
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND
Reviewers found that the program had no aligned surveys of candidates and principals addressing literacy readiness and no plan for sharing collected data with stakeholders. Its corps member improvement plan, in place since 2021, lacked explicit criteria for triggering support, and pre-practicum courses required no graded assignments. The program did not monitor coursework quality, supervising teachers received no annual training, and classroom observation feedback was not used evaluatively. No system shared data with the national course developers who build and facilitate the literacy courses. Memoranda of understanding with districts covered classrooms, class size, and virtual learning but omitted any requirement that districts provide access to high-quality instructional materials.
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS
• Analyze quantitative and qualitative observation feedback data and adapt coursework to identified literacy needs • Give targeted literacy feedback with regular check-ins and an ongoing monitoring and feedback loop • Establish strong district agreements assuring access to high-quality instructional materials and evidence-based early literacy teaching experiences
CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA
Four of the sixteen corrective actions target this review area.

CORRECTIVE ACTION PLAN

Where a review identifies findings that require follow-up, the program develops a corrective action plan with the Division of Elementary and Secondary Education. The recommendations under each review area above are the reviewers' advice; the plan below is the program's formal response, monitored by the Division. Actions are grouped by the review area whose findings prompted them.

TOTAL ACTIONS	HIGH PRIORITY	MEDIUM PRIORITY	LOW PRIORITY
16	15	1	0

The plan sets out 16 corrective actions: 15 high priority and 1 medium priority. The priorities are the plan's own. Some actions target more than one review area, so the per-area counts shown under each review area add to more than the total.

ACTIONS THE PROGRAM IS TAKING

PRIORITY	ACTION	FINDING THAT REQUIRED IT	SUCCESS METRICS
HIGH RA1	Structured Literacy Course Redesign (SVR/Rope/Ehri/Four-Part Processing)	Instruction rated Below; courses light on models, practice, assessment; frameworks not spiraled or applied.	Revised modules published; ≥90% lessons include model to rehearse to coach to assess cycle; ≥80% pass on SoR mastery checks.
HIGH RA1	Concepts of Print (CoP) Integration	CoP absent; Arkansas K-2 standards require CoP.	CoP micro-module live; 100% CMs complete CoP practice/assessment; IRR ≥0.80 on CoP scoring.
HIGH RA1	Oral Language: Language Structures to Instruction	OL below; limited phonology/morphology/syntax/semantics; few assessments.	OL modules add language-structure objectives; ≥2 coached cycles per CM; OL assessment use evident.
HIGH RA1	PA/Phonemic Awareness: Depth + Articulation	PA below; missing isolate/blend/segment/add-delete-substitute; articulation accuracy lacking.	CM rehearses ≥3 PA routines with accuracy; uses multiple assessments; rubric avg ≥3/4.
HIGH RA1	Phonics/Orthography/AWR: Explicit Models + HQIM Transfer	Below; missing models/practice; weak planning/assessment.	Sequence approved; ≥2 modeled lessons and coached rehearsals/CM; decoding/encoding mastery ≥80%.
HIGH RA1	Fluency Toolkit & Application	Fluency below; few exemplars, checks, or application.	Toolkit adopted; CM administers+analyzes fluency measures; prosody rubric used; rehearsal growth evident.
MEDIUM RA1	Vocabulary (Morphology) & Text Comprehension	Vocab and comprehension below; limited explicit strategy teaching and models.	Explicit V/C modules with HQIM; ≥2 modeled mini-lessons/course; unit rubric avg ≥3/4.
HIGH RA1	Writing Across the Curriculum	Writing below; limited process instruction and application.	CM completes ≥1 full writing cycle (plan-teach-assess-revise) with rubric avg ≥3/4; transfer observed.
HIGH RA2	Pre-Service Practice Lab + Simulations (incl. ML & Dyslexia)	Three-week practicum + TOR leaves gaps; need early practice and ML/dyslexia cycles.	Pre-service lab runs weekly; each CM completes 1 ML sim and 2 Tier 1-2 intervention cycles; fidelity ≥80%.
HIGH RA2	HQIM Access & Modeling (Arkansas and Mississippi parity)	Disparity across region; limited HQIM exposure pre-TOR.	100% CMs use HQIM in at least one coached cycle pre-TOR; vetted model videos available; parity plan published.
HIGH RA2	Common Literacy Rubrics + Written & Oral Feedback	Field feedback below; lack of literacy-specific rubrics and written exemplars.	Rubrics in use for practicum & TOR; 100% observations include written feedback with next steps tied to evidence.

PRIORITY	ACTION	FINDING THAT REQUIRED IT	SUCCESS METRICS
HIGH RA2	Co-Observation & Rater Calibration (IRR)	Need alignment across MDLDs/coaches; CLASS not used evaluatively.	Co-obs at initial/mid/final cycles; IRR ≥ 0.80 on literacy look-fors; quarterly calibration.
HIGH RA3	CMIP & Control Gates	Gates below; CMIP lacks clear triggers; pre-practicum lacks graded checks.	Gate criteria published; required graded checks added pre-practicum; CMIP triggers defined; $\geq 90\%$ meet final gate.
HIGH RA3	Pre/Post Assessments & Data Loop to Course Designers	Limited formal assessment; weak data sharing with developers.	Pre/post required in key modules; monthly data briefs sent to national designers; course revisions tracked.
HIGH RA3	Partner MOUs with HQIM & Experience Guarantees	MOUs miss HQIM and experience assurances.	Amended MOUs executed with HQIM clauses and experience menu; quarterly partnership reviews held.
HIGH RA2, RA3	Coach (MDLD/BetterLesson) Selection & Training Standards	Coach selection/credentials not monitored; MDLD PLC not focused on instructional practice.	Coach standards published; quarterly PD on literacy observation & feedback; CLASS used with calibration.

OVERSIGHT

Each action in the plan carries an evidence requirement and a rationale tied to a review finding. The plan leaves the responsible owner and the completion timeline for program leadership to assign, so those entries are not recorded in the plan as issued and are not published here. The Division separately issued a corrective action determination for this program identifying 12 corrective actions, 10 required and 2 recommended. Review area assignments in the table below were made by matching each action's stated rationale to the review area whose findings it answers.

Sources: TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review, Teach For America Greater Delta Region, March 25-28, 2024, conducted under the TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review Framework (2024). Teach For America Greater Delta Region Science of Reading Corrective Action Plan, Arkansas DESE. Rating scale language quoted from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework.